Rotta Critica

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Critical events across the wider Mediterranean, scored for severity from 1 to 9.

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The three most serious stories

- **9 · Strait of Hormuz.** Iran says seven tankers were hit or struck mines in a single night (claim not confirmed by the AP).
- **9 · Sudan.** From 16 to 20 October a wave of drone attacks killed more than 160 people, with massacres in markets and camps for displaced people.
- **8 · Ethiopia and Eritrea.** War in Tigray has resumed, with Eritrean troops reported on Ethiopian territory and fighting in the north.

How to read the scores

The score adds human impact, extent and trajectory, from 1 to 3 each. Bands: high 7-9, medium 4-6, low 1-3. Scores are the author's estimates. Status of this update: the Gulf and Iran, Sudan, the Horn of Africa and the Sahel are verified against sources dated 17-22 October; the Maghreb and Algeria, the rest of Africa, cyber and environment remain at data from 18 October or earlier and should be rechecked before publication. The "partisan source" label marks statements by governments, armies or armed groups that have not been independently verified.

Gulf and Iran

9	**Strait of Hormuz** [partisan source] On 22 October Iranian state television and the navy of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) said seven tankers were hit or struck mines overnight, which would be the most in a single day since the war began on 28 February (Iranian claim; the AP could not confirm it and UKMTO did not report these attacks). According to UKMTO, October is the month with the most reported attacks on merchant ships since March, although some shipowners are reluctant to report incidents. The IRGC threatens US bases in the region if the US Navy keeps escorting ships. Trump says Iran "invents" attacks to push up oil prices and that more crude now passes through than before the war. Iran is re-proposing its seven-day plan to reopen the Strait.
7	**War and talks** On 18 October Iran's parliament approved Mehrdad Akhlaghi Ketabchi as defence minister. On 22 October Netanyahu reportedly told Trump that there is "a job to finish", and US-Israeli plans for a possible resumption of strikes after the US midterm elections are reported (unconfirmed). Iran says it is open to diplomacy but also to self-defence.
6	**Saudi Arabia, Houthi attacks (as of 12 October)** On 10 October a Houthi attack on the passenger terminal at Riyadh airport killed 13 people and injured 309 (Saudi authorities), the deadliest in more than a decade; on 11 October a new strike on Terminal 4 killed one person. In total 18 people died during the week. On 12 October the suspension of operations was extended with no reopening date; I found no later updates. The Houthis threaten to keep hitting Saudi hubs.
5	**Borders and rights (as of 18 October)** [partisan source] Iran and Pakistan have closed some border crossings for security reasons. Opposition sources report EU condemnation of executions in Iran: a partisan source, to be verified.

Sudan and the Horn of Africa

9	**Sudan** From 16 to 20 October a wave of drone attacks killed more than 160 people (Al Jazeera). On 16 October an RSF attack on a gathering of displaced people in Blue Nile killed 41. On 18 October a drone strike on a market in al-Dabba, West Kordofan, killed 80: the RSF blame the army. On 19 October an army drone attack on a market in the disputed Abyei area reportedly killed 153 people (secondary sources, to be verified), and South Sudan summoned Sudan's ambassador. The same day the RSF launched drones at Khartoum airport (4 dead, three of them children) and an army attack on Nyala killed 17. The RSF say the army killed 30 civilians in a cattle market in Nyala on 17 October (partisan claim). The UN says it is alarmed and the Security Council is meeting on Sudan; the risk of famine in Darfur and Kordofan remains.
8	**Ethiopia and Eritrea** War in Tigray has resumed: diplomatic relations between Ethiopia and Eritrea have been cut since 1 October, after drone attacks on Addis Ababa. Federal forces retook Mekelle on 4 October. Since 7 October ACLED and witnesses report Eritrean troops in Tigray; Ethiopia speaks of an advance of up to 60 km and Eritrea denies it, calling the accusations a pretext. On 19-21 October there was fighting at Zana, in north-west Tigray, and at Nirak, in Amhara, where federal forces re-entered while the Agaw group and Tigrayan forces withdrew. According to ACLED, the interim administration in Tigray marks a further breakdown of the Pretoria agreement. The US embassy (7 October) advises against all travel to Amhara, Tigray and Afar. Analysts fear the war could spread to Eritrea and Sudan.
5	**Somalia (as of August)** In 2025 al-Shabaab went on the offensive and retook large areas of the centre-south. On 21 August clashes in Baidoa between local paramilitaries and federal forces left 30 dead (Somali government figure). I found no recent updates.
5	**South Sudan (as of September)** Fighting between the government and the opposition in Upper Nile and Central Equatoria, with looting of clinics.
4	**Chad (as of August)** Crisis Group reports incursions by RSF fighters into Chad and more drones along the border with Sudan.

Sahel and Mali

8	**Mali** [partisan source] On the night of 18-19 October militants from the Islamic State Sahel Province (ISSP) killed 48 people in the Ménaka region, including children and the elderly (AP and Reuters). It appears to be retaliation for an attack on alleged informants by pro-government forces, including Russia's Africa Corps. The army says it has located a base 65 km from Ménaka. Meanwhile JNIM, linked to al-Qaeda, has stepped up attacks on army bases (Dioura, Konna, Sévaré) and on the outskirts of Bamako: it claims to have killed 150 soldiers and captured 93, a figure that cannot be verified. JNIM announced a total blockade of Bamako on 28 April.
7	**Kidal** On 6 October the separatist FLA announced a "controlled withdrawal" from Kidal, which it had held for six months, after army airstrikes backed by Russian fighters. Analysts say the change of control is largely symbolic.

7	**Sahel** [partisan source] JNIM and ISSP are fighting each other fiercely: ISSP claims to have killed 400 JNIM fighters in a foiled ambush in Burkina Faso, a figure that is unverified. The conflict is spreading to western Niger and north-western Nigeria.
5	**Niger (as of 3 October)** [partisan source] Algerian president Tebboune said Algiers sent fighter jets to Niger to help foil a coup attempt (official statement).
5	**North-eastern Nigeria (as of 18 October)** Islamist militants killed 10 soldiers in an attack on a base in Guzamala.

Maghreb and Algeria

5	**Algeria and Morocco** [partisan source] Algiers announced the arrest of 61 Moroccan nationals near Oran, accused of preparing acts against national security (official version, unverified). Diplomatic relations with Rabat have been cut since 2021 and the border has been closed since 1994.
4	**Wildfires in Algeria** [partisan source] On 18 October the defence ministry said investigations into wildfires in several provinces had uncovered a plot by external enemies (government statement, with no independent confirmation). There is no tally of burned area or victims.
4	**Role in the Sahel and travel advice** According to analysts, Algiers is trying to win back the role of security mediator in the region; in July it restored relations with Mali. For travellers: the US rates Algeria at Level 2 and advises against the eastern and southern border areas (Tamanrasset, In Salah, Tindouf). Australia advises a high degree of caution because of terrorism and kidnapping.

Rest of Africa

5	**South Africa** In Johannesburg and Durban violence against immigrants went on for two days, on 9-10 October, with cars set on fire, shops looted and police using tear gas.
4	**Nigeria, electricity** In some areas residents get less than three hours of electricity a day.
2	**Kenya** Ebola has been ruled out for the suspected cases in Laikipia.

Cyber

5	**Ahold Delhaize** The group took its network offline after a cyberattack, disrupting the websites and apps of its supermarket chains in the US.
5	**Exploited vulnerabilities** CISA is calling for urgent patches for BeyondTrust Remote Support and Ivanti Connect Secure. The 13 October Patch Tuesday fixed several critical remote-code-execution flaws in Excel, Word and MSMQ.

3	**Hardware wallets** Researchers report hidden implants in some Trezor and Ledger devices: the impact is limited to a narrow group of users.

Environment

5	**Panama** On 9 October a magnitude 7.6 earthquake struck the centre-south of the country, with its epicentre in Los Santos province. Damage and casualties are not known.
3	**Chile** The storm front of 8-9 October affected 118 people and caused a flood in Las Condes, which was declared a disaster zone. No deaths reported.
3	**South-east Alaska** On 14-16 October heavy rain and wind brought a risk of flooding and landslides.

Coming up

- Hormuz: watch whether Iran and the US resume contacts on the seven-day plan and whether incidents at sea increase.
- 3 November, US midterm elections: according to reports, plans for a possible resumption of strikes would depend on this date.
- 31 October: expiry of the MINURSO mandate for Western Sahara.

Sources

Associated Press and Washington Post (22 October), Times of Israel, AFP and Bernama-Anadolu for the Gulf; US embassy alerts for Saudi Arabia (17 October) and Ethiopia (7 October); Crisis Group (On Our Radar, CrisisWatch); ACLED, UN, Al Jazeera, Reuters; Africa Center for Strategic Studies; Washington Post; CISA; Pan American Health Organization; APS (Algerian government source).

Severity ratings are the author’s estimates. This review is for information only and does not replace official travel advice (the Italian Farnesina, Viaggiare Sicuri, or your own government’s). Data updated to 22 October 2026; for the Maghreb, the rest of Africa, cyber and environment, to 18 October or earlier.